Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 17 · DAYS 634-665

The New Covenant Inaugurated: John

John 1-21

The Word became flesh. Union with Christ, eternal life, and the Spirit's coming.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life."

JOHN 3:16

Light (36, 43), the shepherd (23), and God's nearness (139, 100, 103) beside John.

UNIT 17

In this unit

WEEK 91

634	John 1:1-51	*Reading*
635	John 1:1-18; Philippians 2:5-11; Colossians 1:15-20	*Doctrine*
636	John 2:1-3:36	*Reading*
637	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 92

638	John 3:1-21; Ezekiel 36:25-27; Titus 3:3-7	*Doctrine*
639	Psalm 36	*Psalm*
640	Psalm 139:1-18	*Psalm*
641	John 4:1-54	*Reading*
642	John 4:19-26; Psalm 95; Hebrews 12:18-29	*Doctrine*
643	John 5:1-47	*Reading*
644	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 93

645	John 6:1-71	*Reading*
646	John 7:1-8:11	*Reading*
647	John 8:12-59	*Reading*
648	Psalm 119:97-120	*Psalm*
649	Psalm 43	*Psalm*
650	John 9:1-10:21	*Reading*
651	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 94

652	John 10:22-11:57	*Reading*
653	John 12:1-50	*Reading*
654	John 13:1-14:31	*Reading*
655	Psalm 23	*Psalm*

656	Psalm 100	*Psalm*
657	Psalm 103	*Psalm*
658	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 95

659	John 15:1-16:33	*Reading*
660	John 17:1-26	*Reading*
661	John 18:1-19:16	*Reading*
662	John 19:17-42	*Reading*
663	John 20:1-21:25	*Reading*
664	Review and Reflection	*Review*
665	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 634 · WEEK 91

John 1:1-51

The Word made flesh; the first disciples, "come and see"

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 1:1-51. John begins before creation, with the Word, then moves to John the Baptist, the first disciples, and Nathanael. Read verses 1-18 slowly, as the prologue to the whole Gospel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

John was one of the Twelve, the disciple whom Jesus loved, and he wrote this Gospel late in his life. He tells us his purpose near the end: that we may believe Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and have life in his name. His Gospel is different from Matthew, Mark, and Luke. It contains very little of the parables and much more of Jesus' long conversations, and it is built around seven signs and seven "I AM" statements. It begins with a hymn that takes us back to the beginning of everything.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (1:1).
2. "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it" (1:5).
3. "But to all who did receive him, who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God" (1:12).
4. "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth" (1:14).
5. "No one has ever seen God; the only God, who is at the Father's side, he has made him known" (1:18).

6. “Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!” (1:29).
7. “Philip said to him, Come and see” (1:46).
8. “You will see heaven opened, and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man” (1:51).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Gospel opens with the words of Genesis 1:1, “In the beginning.” But now the focus is not on creation but on the one through whom it came. The Word was with God (distinct from the Father) and the Word was God (fully divine). He was in the beginning, so he is eternal. “All things were made through him,” so he is Creator. In him was life, and that life was the light of men.

Then John says that the light shines in the darkness and the darkness has not overcome it. He introduces John the Baptist, a witness who points to the light. The true light came into the world, yet the world did not know him, and his own people did not receive him. But to those who did receive him, he gave the right to become children of God, born not of blood or the will of the flesh but of God. That promise is the core of the Gospel.

Verse 14 is the center of the prologue: “The Word became flesh and dwelt among us.” The word for dwelt means pitched his tent, an echo of the tabernacle in the wilderness. God has come to live with his people in a person. “We have seen his glory,” says John, “full of grace and truth,” which recalls the LORD’s self-revelation to Moses in Exodus 34. The law was given through Moses, but grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. No one has seen God, but the Son has made him known.

The rest of the chapter is a parade of titles. John the Baptist points to Jesus: “Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!” Andrew finds Peter, saying, “We have found the Messiah.” Philip finds Nathanael, who doubts that anything good could come from Nazareth, and Philip answers with an invitation: “Come and see.” Jesus tells Nathanael that he saw him under the fig tree, and Nathanael confesses, “You are the Son of God! You are the King of Israel!” Jesus promises he will see greater things: heaven opened and angels ascending and descending on the Son of Man, an echo of Jacob’s ladder at Bethel. Jesus himself is the meeting place between heaven and earth.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:1-3 is the beginning John echoes. Proverbs 8:22-31 speaks of wisdom beside God at creation. Exodus 25:8 and 33:18-23 are about God dwelling with his people and showing his glory. Exodus 34:6 is the source of “grace and truth.” Isaiah 53:7 is the Lamb. Genesis 28:12 is

Jacob's ladder. Hebrews 1:1-3 states that the Son is the radiance of the glory of God. 1 John 1:1-4 is John's own testimony to what he saw and touched.

STEP 6

Application

Read John 1:1-18 aloud three times. Which phrase strikes you most? Write it down.

Take Philip's invitation, "Come and see," and ask yourself who you could invite to see Jesus.

Praise Jesus today as Creator, as the light in darkness, and as the Lamb who takes away sin.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for becoming flesh and making his dwelling among us.

Tell him, "I'll come and see," and ask him to show you more.

Ask him to give you the right to be his child.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 635 · WEEK 91

John 1:1-18; Philippians 2:5-11; Colossians 1:15-20

The Person of Christ, Incarnation

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 1:1-18, Philippians 2:5-11, and Colossians 1:15-20. Today is a doctrinal pause on the person of Christ: who he is, and what it means that the Word became flesh. Notice what each passage says about his divinity and his humanity.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three of the greatest passages about Christ in the New Testament come from two authors. John writes a prologue to his Gospel. Paul, writing from prison to the Philippians, quotes what is probably an early hymn. In Colossians, he answers a church troubled by false teaching and puts Christ above all. The church has summarized these teachings in the doctrine of the incarnation: that the eternal Son took on a true human nature without ceasing to be God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God” (John 1:1).
2. “And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us” (John 1:14).
3. “Who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped” (Philippians 2:6).
4. “But emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men” (Philippians 2:7).

5. “And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross” (Philippians 2:8).
6. “And every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father” (Philippians 2:11).
7. “He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation” (Colossians 1:15).
8. “For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell” (Colossians 1:19).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The incarnation is the central miracle of the Christian faith: the eternal Son of God, the second person of the Trinity, took to himself a true human nature, with a body and a soul, and was born of the virgin Mary. He did not stop being God; he added humanity. The church confessed at Chalcedon in AD 451 that Christ is one person in two natures, fully God and fully man, “without confusion, without change, without division, without separation.” Christians have long held this because the Scriptures teach both halves. Jesus is called God, worshiped, and credited with creating all things. And he hungers, thirsts, weeps, grows weary, suffers, and dies. If he were not truly God, he could not save us. If he were not truly man, he could not stand in our place. “Emptied himself” in Philippians 2 does not mean he gave up his divine nature, but that he laid aside the privileges of glory and took the form of a servant. The incarnation is the beginning of his work of redemption: the one who became what we are, so that we might become what he is, children of God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

John tells us who the Word is. He was with God and was God, the agent of creation, the source of life and light. Then comes the most astonishing sentence of the Bible: “The Word became flesh.” The one who made the world entered it. Notice that John does not say the Word “appeared” to be flesh or “entered” a body. He became flesh. He took our nature and lived among us.

Paul gives the path of the incarnation in Philippians 2. Christ Jesus was in the form of God, and did not treat equality with God as something to hold on to. He emptied himself, taking the form of a servant. He humbled himself, became obedient, and went all the way to death on a cross. Therefore God has highly exalted him and given him the name above every name, “that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow.” The pattern is descent and ascent. Paul’s reason for telling the story is practical: “Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus.” The incarnation is also a model for humility.

In Colossians, Paul speaks of the cosmic Christ. He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation, which means supreme in rank and not first created, for "by him all things were created." He holds all things together. He is the head of the church, the firstborn from the dead. All the fullness of God dwells in him, and through him God reconciles all things to himself, making peace by the blood of his cross.

Put these three together. The one who made the stars became a baby. The one who holds the universe together was carried by his mother. The one who is Lord of all died on a cross. This is why the church has always been amazed. Our salvation depends on who he is.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 9:6 calls the child "Mighty God." Isaiah 45:23 is the verse Paul uses in Philippians 2:10-11. Hebrews 1:1-4 and 2:14-18 speak of the Son's deity and humanity. 1 Timothy 3:16 calls it a great mystery. 1 John 4:2 says every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God. Galatians 4:4 says God sent his Son, born of woman. Luke 1:35 says the child will be called holy, the Son of God.

STEP 6

Application

Say the Chalcedonian summary aloud: Jesus is fully God and fully man, one person. Thank him for each half.

Read Philippians 2:5 again. Where is Christ calling you to take the form of a servant?

When you feel that God is far away, remember that the Word became flesh and dwelt among us.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus, the Word who was with God and was God.
- Thank him for emptying himself and taking the form of a servant.
- Tell him what it means that he became one of us.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

“And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth.”

JOHN 1:14

DAY 636 · WEEK 91

John 2:1-3:36

Cana; Temple cleansing; Nicodemus, born again

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 2:1-3:36. Jesus turns water into wine at Cana, cleanses the temple, and talks with Nicodemus at night. John the Baptist then speaks of Jesus' increase. Notice that John calls miracles "signs," pointing to something beyond themselves.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

John does not record Jesus' birth or temptation. After the prologue and the first disciples, he moves to a wedding in Cana of Galilee. Jesus' first sign is there. Then he goes to Jerusalem for Passover, clears the temple, and meets a ruler of the Jews, Nicodemus, who comes by night. John 3:16 comes from this conversation and has been called the gospel in a sentence. It is also the anchor verse of this unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do whatever he tells you" (2:5).
2. "This, the first of his signs, Jesus did at Cana in Galilee, and manifested his glory. And his disciples believed in him" (2:11).
3. "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up" (2:19).
4. "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God" (3:3).
5. "The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit" (3:8).
6. "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life" (3:16).

7. “He must increase, but I must decrease” (3:30).
8. “Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life; whoever does not obey the Son shall not see life, but the wrath of God remains on him” (3:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At the wedding in Cana, the wine runs out, a serious embarrassment. Mary tells Jesus, and then tells the servants, “Do whatever he tells you.” Jesus has them fill six stone jars, used for Jewish purification, with water, and the water becomes wine, better than what was served before. John says this was the first of Jesus’ signs and “manifested his glory.” The abundance of wine, perhaps 120 to 180 gallons, points to the messianic age, which the prophets described as a feast of wine. The old purification is replaced by the new joy.

In Jerusalem, Jesus drives out the sellers from the temple. When asked for a sign, he says, “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.” John explains that he was speaking about the temple of his body. Jesus is the true place where God and man meet, and he will rise on the third day.

Nicodemus, a Pharisee and a member of the council, comes at night. He recognizes that Jesus is a teacher from God. Jesus replies abruptly: “Unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God.” Nicodemus is puzzled. How can anyone enter the womb a second time? Jesus explains that one must be born of water and the Spirit. The Spirit, like the wind, is sovereign and invisible but his work can be seen. A teacher of Israel should have known this from Ezekiel 36. Jesus then says that as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so the Son of Man must be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life.

Then comes verse 16. God’s love is the source. The world is the object, the whole sinful world. The gift is his only Son. The condition is belief, and the result is that we do not perish but have eternal life. The next verse says God did not send his Son to condemn the world, but that the world might be saved through him.

The chapter closes with John the Baptist, who rejoices that Jesus is gaining followers. He is the friend of the bridegroom. “He must increase, but I must decrease.” The one who comes from above is above all. And verse 36 sets the choice before everyone: believe and live, or reject and remain under wrath.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 25:6 and Amos 9:13-14 promise abundant wine in the age to come. Psalm 69:9 is the zeal for the house that the disciples recall. Malachi 3:1 promises that the Lord will suddenly come to his temple. Ezekiel 36:25-27 describes the cleansing and the new heart. Numbers 21:4-9 is the bronze serpent. Romans 5:8 and 1 John 4:9-10 echo God's love in giving his Son. Ephesians 2:8-9 says we are saved by grace through faith.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize John 3:16 this week. It is the memory verse for the unit.

Say "He must increase, but I must decrease" as a prayer at the start of your day.

Think of a Nicodemus in your life, a thoughtful person with questions, and pray for them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for revealing his glory.

Thank him for the new birth, and ask him to keep working in you.

Tell him you believe, and ask him to deepen it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 637 · WEEK 91

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 1:14 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

REST

Meditation

This single verse is the heart of the Christmas message, and of the whole Gospel of John.

"The Word." In Greek, logos. To Greek readers, it was the rational order behind the universe. To Jewish readers, it was God's creative and revealing speech. John says that this Word is a person, the eternal Son who was with God and was God.

"Became flesh." Flesh means our weak, mortal humanity. He did not hover above it. He took it on. The infinite entered the finite, and the Creator became a creature.

"And dwelt among us." The verb is "tabernacled." Just as God's glory filled the tent in the wilderness, so God's glory now lives in a human body. God has pitched his tent in our neighborhood.

"We have seen his glory." John is a witness. He saw the glory on the mountain, at Cana, and at the cross. It was a glory of weakness as well as power.

“Full of grace and truth.” Grace is God’s free favor. Truth is God’s faithfulness and reality. In Christ we get both.

When you wonder what God is like, say this verse. Look at Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Gospel of Luke, with the cross, the thief’s prayer, the empty tomb, and the walk to Emmaus, where Jesus opened the Scriptures and showed that they are about him. Then you began the Gospel of John. The prologue told you that the Word who was with God and was God became flesh and dwelt among us. Your doctrinal pause on the incarnation set John’s words beside Philippians 2 and Colossians 1: the one who made all things emptied himself, became a servant, and died on a cross. In John 2 and 3 you saw Jesus turn water into wine, cleanse the temple, and tell Nicodemus that he must be born again. You met the verse that sums up the Gospel: “For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

John says the Word became flesh and dwelt among us. What does it mean for you that God chose to live among us as a human being?

Jesus’ first sign was turning water into wine, a picture of the joy of the new covenant. How does Jesus bring joy where there was only emptiness?

Nicodemus came by night with questions. What is one honest question you would bring to Jesus right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for dwelling among us, full of grace and truth.

Thank him for new birth.

Rest in him.

DAY 638 · WEEK 92

John 3:1-21; Ezekiel 36:25-27; Titus 3:3-7

Regeneration and the New Birth

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 3:1-21, Ezekiel 36:25-27, and Titus 3:3-7. Today is a doctrinal pause on regeneration, the new birth. Notice who does the work in each passage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus told Nicodemus that a person must be born again. Nicodemus, a teacher of Israel, was confused, and Jesus replied that he should have understood. The promise of a new heart is found in the prophets, especially Ezekiel. In Titus, Paul speaks of the same event in the life of the believer: the washing of regeneration. The doctrine of regeneration is the teaching that God, by his Spirit, gives new spiritual life to those who were dead in sin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God" (John 3:3).
2. "Unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God" (John 3:5).
3. "That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit" (John 3:6).
4. "I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean from all your uncleannesses" (Ezekiel 36:25).
5. "And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you" (Ezekiel 36:26).

6. “And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh” (Ezekiel 36:26).

7. “And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes” (Ezekiel 36:27).

8. “He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit” (Titus 3:5).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Regeneration is the act of God by which he gives new spiritual life to a person who was dead in sin. It is the beginning of the Christian life. Jesus calls it being born again or born from above. The Bible teaches that we are born spiritually dead (Ephesians 2:1) and cannot save ourselves. God makes us alive. In the language of Ezekiel, he replaces a heart of stone with a heart of flesh and puts his Spirit within us. As in physical birth, the one being born does not bring about the birth: it is a work of God, “not of the will of man, but of God” (John 1:13). Reformed Christians have generally taught that regeneration comes first in order and produces the faith and repentance by which we respond to the gospel. Other evangelicals place regeneration and faith more closely together, but all agree that salvation is the Spirit’s gift and that those who are born again will show it in a new love for God, new obedience, and perseverance. It is not something we achieve. It is something we receive.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus’ words to Nicodemus show how radical the need is. A morally serious, religious man needs not improvement but new birth. “That which is born of the flesh is flesh.” Human nature cannot produce spiritual life. Only “that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.” Then Jesus compares the Spirit to the wind. You cannot control it, and you cannot predict it, but you can see its effects. The new birth is God’s sovereign work.

The Old Testament had promised it. Ezekiel 36 speaks of a day when God would gather his people, cleanse them with water, give them a new heart, and put his Spirit within them so that they would walk in his ways. This is the new covenant promise, along with Jeremiah 31. When Jesus mentions water and the Spirit, Nicodemus should have thought of this passage. The problem under the old covenant was a heart of stone, a will that would not obey. The solution is not better instruction but a new heart.

Paul says the same in Titus 3. He describes our past: foolish, disobedient, led astray, slaves to passions, hated and hating. Then “the goodness and loving kindness of God our Savior appeared.” He saved us not because of works but according to his own mercy, “by the

washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior." Regeneration is purely a gift, and the result is that we become heirs with the hope of eternal life.

The doctrine comforts and humbles. It humbles because we contributed nothing to our new life. It comforts because the one who began it will finish it. And it presses us to look for the signs of life in ourselves, such as love for Christ, hatred of sin, and a desire to obey, and to pray for those who are dead in sin that God would make them alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 31:33 and Ezekiel 11:19-20 also promise a new heart. Deuteronomy 30:6 speaks of the circumcision of the heart. Ephesians 2:1-5 says we were dead in trespasses and God made us alive with Christ. 1 Peter 1:3 and 1:23 speak of being born again. 2 Corinthians 5:17 says anyone in Christ is a new creation. John 1:12-13 says we are born of God. 1 John 3:9 and 5:1 describe those who are born of God.

STEP 6

Application

Look for evidence of the Spirit's work in you: love for God, sorrow for sin, hunger for the Word. Thank God for each.

Pray by name for someone who seems far from God. Ask God to give them a new heart.

Read Ezekiel 36:25-27 as a prayer, in the first person: "Give me a new heart and put your Spirit in me."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making you alive when you were dead in sin.

Thank him for the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Spirit.

Ask him to show you where new life is evident in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

“God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.”

JOHN 4:24

DAY 639 · WEEK 92

Psalm 36

Steadfast love extends to the heavens, the fountain of life

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 36. It sets the darkness of the wicked heart beside the vast steadfast love of God, and it ends with the fountain of life. Read verses 5 to 9 aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 36 is a psalm of David, "the servant of the LORD." It begins with a picture of the wicked person, then turns sharply to the character of God. At the center is the fountain of life: "In your light do we see light." It sits well beside John, which says the true light has come into the world and that in him was life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Transgression speaks to the wicked deep in his heart; there is no fear of God before his eyes" (v. 1).
2. "Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens, your faithfulness to the clouds" (v. 5).
3. "Your righteousness is like the mountains of God; your judgments are like the great deep" (v. 6).
4. "How precious is your steadfast love, O God! The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings" (v. 7).
5. "They feast on the abundance of your house, and you give them drink from the river of your delights" (v. 8).
6. "For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light" (v. 9).

7. “Oh, continue your steadfast love to those who know you, and your righteousness to the upright of heart!” (v. 10).

8. “There the evildoers lie fallen; they are thrust down, unable to rise” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts in a dark place, the heart of the wicked. Sin whispers to him, and he has no fear of God. He flatters himself, so that he does not see his guilt. His words are trouble and deceit, he plots evil on his bed, and he does not reject what is wrong. The root of wickedness is forgetting God.

Then verse 5 begins with a sudden shift, like a sunrise: “Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens.” The contrast could not be greater. The wicked heart is small and self-absorbed. God’s love reaches the sky. His faithfulness reaches the clouds. His righteousness is like the highest mountains, and his judgments are like the deepest sea. He cares for people and animals alike.

“How precious is your steadfast love, O God!” It is precious because it is a refuge: “The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings.” The image is of a bird sheltering its young. They feast on the abundance of God’s house, and he gives them drink from the river of his delights, an image drawn from Eden, whose river watered the garden.

Verse 9 is the heart: “For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light.” Life is not something we have in ourselves. It flows from God. And we do not see truth by our own light but by his. Only in the light of God can we see anything rightly.

In John’s Gospel, Jesus is the fountain of life and the light. “In him was life, and the life was the light of men.” He told the woman at the well that he would give living water, and on the last day of the feast he cried, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink.” The psalmist’s longing is answered in Christ. The psalm ends with a prayer for continued love and protection, and with the wicked fallen, unable to rise.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2:10 describes the river of Eden. Psalm 17:8 and 57:1 use the shadow of wings. Psalm 46:4 speaks of the river whose streams make glad the city of God. Jeremiah 2:13 says Israel forsook the fountain of living waters. John 1:4, 4:14, 7:37-38, and 8:12 apply this imagery to Jesus. Revelation 22:1-5 describes the river of life and the light of God himself.

STEP 6

Application

Say verse 9 aloud and ask, “Where am I looking for life apart from God?”

Meditate on the size of God’s love: the heavens, the clouds, the mountains, the deep.

Take refuge under his wings. Name one worry and bring it to him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for his steadfast love that reaches the heavens.
- Tell him what it means to take refuge in the shadow of his wings.
- Thank him for the fountain of life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

“God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.”

JOHN 4:24

DAY 640 · WEEK 92

Psalm 139:1-18

O LORD, you have searched me and known me

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 139:1-18. David marvels that God knows him completely. Notice how the psalm moves from knowing to presence to creation to wonder.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 139 is one of the most personal psalms. David reflects on the fact that God knows everything about him, is present everywhere, and made him in the womb. The last verses (19 to 24) turn to a prayer against the wicked and a prayer to be searched, but today's reading covers the first eighteen verses, the part that has comforted many. It follows the Psalm 36 theme of God's vast care.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, you have searched me and known me!" (v. 1).
2. "You know when I sit down and when I rise up; you discern my thoughts from afar" (v. 2).
3. "Even before a word is on my tongue, behold, O LORD, you know it altogether" (v. 4).
4. "Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence?" (v. 7).
5. "For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother's womb" (v. 13).
6. "I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Wonderful are your works; my soul knows it very well" (v. 14).
7. "Your eyes saw my unformed substance; in your book were written, every one of them, the days that were formed for me, when as yet there was none of them" (v. 16).

8 “How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with complete knowledge. God has searched David and known him. He knows when David sits and stands, knows his thoughts from far off, and knows his words before he speaks them. He hems David in, behind and before, and lays his hand on him. David’s response: “Such knowledge is too wonderful for me; it is high; I cannot attain it.”

This could feel threatening, to be known so completely. But for David it is a comfort. The question in verses 7 to 12 shows that he has considered escape and found that there is none. “Where shall I go from your Spirit?” If he goes up to heaven, God is there. If he makes his bed in Sheol, God is there. If he takes the wings of the morning and dwells in the uttermost parts of the sea, even there God’s hand will lead him. Even darkness is not dark to God. The presence of God, which could be terrifying for a sinner, is a source of safety for a child.

Then the psalm goes back before birth. God formed his inward parts and knitted him together in his mother’s womb. “I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made.” This is a deep affirmation of the value of every human being. Each of us is a work of God, planned and watched over from the beginning. In his book were written all the days that were formed for us, before any of them existed. Our lives are known to God and held by him.

And David’s response is awe: “How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them! If I would count them, they are more than the sand.” When I awake, he says, I am still with you.

In John, Jesus is shown to know people completely. He knows Nathanael under the fig tree and the Samaritan woman’s history. To be known by him is to be known by God, and to be loved.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 1:5 says God knew the prophet before he formed him in the womb. Job 10:8-12 and Psalm 119:73 also speak of God’s making. Proverbs 15:3 says the eyes of the LORD are in every place. John 1:47-49 and 4:16-19 show Jesus knowing people. Hebrews 4:13 says no creature is hidden from his sight. Matthew 10:29-31 says the very hairs of your head are numbered. Ephesians 2:10 says we are his workmanship.

STEP 6

Application

Read verses 1 to 6 slowly, and let yourself be fully known. Is that comforting or uncomfortable? Tell God.

Thank God for how he made you, including the parts you struggle to accept.

Share Psalm 139:13-14 with someone who feels worthless.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he has searched you and knows you.

Tell him what you want him to see in you today.

Praise him that you are fearfully and wonderfully made.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

DAY 641 · WEEK 92

John 4:1-54

The Samaritan woman; living water; the official's son

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 4:1-54. Jesus meets a Samaritan woman at a well, offers her living water, and many in her town believe. He then heals an official's son from a distance. Notice who Jesus talks to and what he offers.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus leaves Judea and goes north to Galilee, taking the road through Samaria, which most Jews avoided because of centuries of hostility. At noon he sits by Jacob's well, tired, while his disciples go to buy food. A woman comes to draw water at a time when no one else would be there. Jews and Samaritans did not share dishes, and a rabbi did not usually speak with a woman in public. Jesus breaks every barrier.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give me a drink" (4:7).
2. "If you knew the gift of God, and who it is that is saying to you, Give me a drink, you would have asked him, and he would have given you living water" (4:10).
3. "The water that I will give him will become in him a spring of water welling up to eternal life" (4:14).
4. "Come, see a man who told me all that I ever did. Can this be the Christ?" (4:29).
5. "I who speak to you am he" (4:26).
6. "My food is to do the will of him who sent me and to accomplish his work" (4:34).
7. "We have heard for ourselves, and we know that this is indeed the Savior of the world" (4:42).

8 “Go; your son will live” (4:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus asks a Samaritan woman for a drink. The request surprises her. Then he turns it around: if she knew who was asking, she would ask him for living water. She thinks he means running water, but he is speaking of the Spirit, a spring welling up in a person to eternal life. The woman asks for it, perhaps still half joking, and Jesus says, “Go, call your husband.” She has had five husbands, and the man she lives with now is not her husband. Jesus knows her whole story, and he does not shrink from it. His aim is not to shame her but to bring her to the truth.

She changes the subject to the old argument over where to worship. Jesus tells her that the hour is coming, and is now here, when true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth. We will return to this in the doctrinal pause. Then she says, “I know that Messiah is coming,” and Jesus says, “I who speak to you am he.” This is the first time in the Gospel that Jesus openly says he is the Messiah, and he says it to a Samaritan woman with a past.

She leaves her water jar and goes to the town, saying, “Come, see a man who told me all that I ever did. Can this be the Christ?” She is the first evangelist in John, and her witness is simple. Many Samaritans believe because of her word, and then they invite Jesus to stay two days. Then many more believe, and they say, “We know that this is indeed the Savior of the world.” The Gospel crosses the boundary of ethnicity.

Meanwhile the disciples are puzzled that Jesus has no need of food. He says, “My food is to do the will of him who sent me.” He points to the fields white for harvest.

Back in Cana, an official comes from Capernaum begging Jesus to heal his dying son. Jesus says, “Go; your son will live.” The man believes the word and goes, and finds that the fever left at the very hour. This is the second sign. Faith takes Jesus at his word.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 29:1-12, Exodus 2:15-21, and Genesis 24 are Old Testament wells where significant meetings happen. Isaiah 12:3 and 55:1 promise water for the thirsty. Jeremiah 2:13 speaks of the fountain of living water. Ezekiel 47:1-12 pictures a river flowing from the temple. John 7:37-39 explains that the living water is the Spirit. Acts 8:4-25 records the gospel’s spread to Samaria. Revelation 21:6 and 22:17 offer the water of life freely.

STEP 6

Application

Think about what you drink from to satisfy your thirst, such as approval, success, or comfort. Bring it to Jesus.

Like the woman, tell someone simply what Jesus has done in your life.

Who is the Samaritan in your life, a person it would be awkward to talk to about Jesus? Ask God for a chance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus that he knows everything about you, and let that be good news.
- Ask him for living water.
- Ask him to teach you to tell others about him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

DAY 642 · WEEK 92

John 4:19-26; Psalm 95; Hebrews 12:18-29

Worship

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 4:19-26, Psalm 95, and Hebrews 12:18-29. Today is a doctrinal pause on worship. Notice who is worshiped, how, and why.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Samaritan woman asked Jesus where one should worship, on Mount Gerizim or in Jerusalem. Jesus answered with a statement about worship that changes everything. Psalm 95 is one of the great invitations to worship in the Psalter, and Hebrews 12 describes the nature of worship under the new covenant. Together they teach that worship is the purpose for which we were made, and that it is directed to the Father, through the Son, in the Spirit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Woman, believe me, the hour is coming when neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem will you worship the Father” (John 4:21).
2. “The hour is coming, and is now here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father is seeking such people to worship him” (John 4:23).
3. “God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth” (John 4:24).
4. “Oh come, let us sing to the LORD; let us make a joyful noise to the rock of our salvation!” (Psalm 95:1).
5. “Oh come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD, our Maker!” (Psalm 95:6).

6. “For he is our God, and we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand” (Psalm 95:7).
7. “Therefore let us be grateful for receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, and thus let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe” (Hebrews 12:28).
8. “For our God is a consuming fire” (Hebrews 12:29).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Worship is the response of the whole person to the worth of God. It is what we were made for. In the Bible, true worship has three marks. First, it is directed to the right object: the triune God alone, not any idol, whether carved or imagined. Second, it is offered “in spirit and truth.” Jesus does not abolish outward forms, but he insists that worship be from the heart, by the Spirit, and according to the truth that God has revealed in Christ and in his Word. Third, it is offered through Christ, our mediator. Under the old covenant, worship centered on the temple, the priests, and the sacrifices. Now Jesus is the temple, the priest, and the sacrifice, and we draw near through him. The Reformed tradition has taught that God is to be worshiped as he commands in Scripture, and so gathered worship centers on the reading and preaching of the Word, prayer, singing, and the sacraments. Worship is also all of life: Romans 12:1 calls us to present our bodies as a living sacrifice. It is joyful and reverent at once, for God is both our Father and a consuming fire.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Samaritan woman raises a question of place. Jesus says the place no longer matters. A new era is beginning in which worship is not tied to a mountain or a building. The reason is that the Father is seeking worshipers, and God is spirit. He cannot be confined to a location. “In spirit” means by the Holy Spirit, who makes the heart alive. “In truth” means according to the reality revealed in Christ, who is the truth.

Psalm 95 gives a picture of what worship looks like. It begins with singing and a joyful noise, because the LORD is a great God and a great King above all gods, who holds the depths of the earth and the heights of the mountains, and made the sea and dry land. Then it moves from joy to reverence: “Let us worship and bow down; let us kneel.” We worship because he is our Maker, and our shepherd, and we are the sheep of his hand. Then the psalm ends with a warning not to harden our hearts as Israel did in the wilderness. Worship requires listening: “Today, if you hear his voice.”

Hebrews 12 contrasts Sinai and Zion. Israel came to a mountain of fire, darkness, and trembling, and begged that no further word be spoken. But believers have come to Mount Zion, to the heavenly Jerusalem, to innumerable angels, to the assembly of the firstborn, to God the judge, and "to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and to the sprinkled blood." We receive a kingdom that cannot be shaken. Therefore we offer acceptable worship "with reverence and awe, for our God is a consuming fire."

True worship holds both together: the intimacy of a child with his Father and the awe of a creature before the Holy One.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 12 and 1 Kings 8 deal with the place of worship under the old covenant. Isaiah 66:1-2 says heaven is God's throne, and he looks to the humble. Psalm 29:2 says to worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness. Romans 12:1-2 calls for living sacrifice. Philippians 3:3 describes those who worship by the Spirit of God. Revelation 4 and 5 show worship in heaven. Hebrews 10:19-22 invites us to draw near.

STEP 6

Application

Prepare for worship this Sunday: pray, rest well, and arrive ready to listen.

Take one thing you do this week, such as work, and offer it as worship.

Sing Psalm 95 or a hymn to God in private, even if you're not a singer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to worship in spirit and truth.

Ask him to teach you to worship even when you do not feel like it.

Praise him as the great God and great King.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

“God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.”

JOHN 4:24

DAY 643 · WEEK 92

John 5:1-47

Healing at Bethesda; the Son's authority; witnesses to Jesus

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 5:1-47. Jesus heals a man at the pool of Bethesda on the Sabbath, and the leaders want to kill him. He then speaks at length about his relationship to the Father. Notice the claims he makes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus returns to Jerusalem for a feast. At the pool of Bethesda, many sick people lie waiting for healing. One man has been ill for thirty-eight years. Jesus heals him, and since it is the Sabbath, the leaders object. What follows is one of the longest and most direct claims to deity in the Gospels. Jesus makes himself equal to the Father in work, honor, and authority, and then lists the witnesses to his claim.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do you want to be healed?" (5:6).
2. "Get up, take up your bed, and walk" (5:8).
3. "My Father is working until now, and I am working" (5:17).
4. "Calling God his own Father, making himself equal with God" (5:18).
5. "Whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me has eternal life. He does not come into judgment, but has passed from death to life" (5:24).
6. "The hour is coming, and is now here, when the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God, and those who hear will live" (5:25).
7. "You search the Scriptures because you think that in them you have eternal life; and it is they that bear witness about me" (5:39).

8 “For if you believed Moses, you would believe me; for he wrote of me” (5:46).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The man by the pool is helpless. He has no one to put him in the water. Jesus asks, “Do you want to be healed?” and instead of answering yes, the man gives an excuse. Jesus does not need his help. He says, “Get up, take up your bed, and walk,” and the man is healed at once. The man did nothing to earn it. This is grace.

The leaders do not rejoice. The healing was on the Sabbath, and the man is carrying his mat. When they persecute Jesus, he answers, “My Father is working until now, and I am working.” God does not stop working on the Sabbath, because he sustains the world and upholds the lives of his creatures. Jesus claims the same prerogative. The leaders understand perfectly: he is “making himself equal with God,” and they seek to kill him.

Jesus does not retreat. He doubles down. The Son does only what he sees the Father doing. The Father shows him everything. Like the Father, he raises the dead and gives life to whom he will. The Father has given all judgment to the Son, “that all may honor the Son, just as they honor the Father.” Whoever does not honor the Son does not honor the Father. And then, a promise: “Whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me has eternal life. He does not come into judgment, but has passed from death to life.” Eternal life is not only future. Believers have already passed from death to life.

Jesus then lists witnesses: John the Baptist, the works he does, the Father himself, and the Scriptures. The leaders search the Scriptures, thinking they give life, but they refuse to come to him. The Scriptures are not an end in themselves. They point to him. “Moses wrote of me.” It is possible to study the Bible diligently and still miss its center. The leaders are an example of how not to read, and Jesus teaches us to read the Scriptures to find Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 20:8-11 and Deuteronomy 5:12-15 give the Sabbath commandment. Isaiah 40:28 says God does not grow weary. Daniel 7:13-14 gives the Son of Man authority. Daniel 12:2 speaks of the resurrection of the dead. Deuteronomy 18:15-19 promises a prophet like Moses. Luke 24:27 and 24:44 say the Scriptures speak of Christ. Romans 5:1 and 8:1 say there is now no condemnation. Ephesians 2:4-5 says we are made alive.

STEP 6

Application

Answer Jesus’ question honestly: do you want to be healed? Where do you make excuses?

When you read the Bible, ask: where does this point to Jesus?

Thank God that you have passed from death to life. Say it aloud.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell Jesus you are helpless, and let him ask whether you want to be healed.

Thank him that he heals by his word alone.

Ask him to give you life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

DAY 644 · WEEK 92

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 4:24 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to a Samaritan woman, in answer to her question about where worship should take place. It is among the most important sentences in the Bible on worship.

"God is spirit." God is not a physical being, limited to a place or an image. He is invisible, everywhere present, and alive. That is why Israel was forbidden to make images, and why he cannot be confined to a mountain or a building.

"And those who worship him." Worship is not optional or peripheral. It is the reason we exist. The Father is seeking worshipers. He is not indifferent to whether we come.

"Must worship in spirit." This means with the heart, through the Holy Spirit, who gives us new life. Worship that is only outward ritual is empty. Worship in spirit comes from the inside.

“And truth.” Worship must be shaped by what God has actually revealed. It is not whatever feels sincere. Jesus himself is the truth, and the Scriptures are the truth about him.

When you feel that your worship is dull, or you do not know how to come to God, say this verse. The Father is seeking you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you studied the new birth. In the doctrinal pause on regeneration, you saw that being born again is God’s work, promised in Ezekiel 36 and described in Titus 3 as the washing of regeneration and renewal by the Holy Spirit. Psalm 36 showed you the steadfast love that extends to the heavens, and the fountain of life. Psalm 139 reminded you that you are fully known and fearfully and wonderfully made. In John 4 you watched Jesus offer living water to a Samaritan woman, and saw a whole town believe. The doctrinal pause on worship taught you that the Father seeks those who worship in spirit and truth, through Christ. In John 5 you saw Jesus heal a man who could not help himself, and heard him claim equality with the Father and promise that whoever believes has passed from death to life.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Regeneration is God’s work, not ours. How does that change the way you think about your own faith, and about praying for those who do not believe?

Jesus offered the Samaritan woman living water, the gift of the Spirit. Where do you most need that water right now?

Jesus said the Scriptures bear witness about him. How does keeping that in mind change the way you read the Bible?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for giving you new birth.

Thank him for seeking you as a worshiper.

Ask him to teach you to worship in spirit and truth.

DAY 645 · WEEK 93

John 6:1-71

The bread of life, sovereign grace and discipleship

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 6:1-71. Jesus feeds the five thousand, walks on the sea, and then teaches in the synagogue at Capernaum that he is the bread of life. Many disciples leave. Notice the tension between God's drawing and the human response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is near Passover, and a great crowd has followed Jesus because of his signs. The feeding of the five thousand is the only miracle, apart from the resurrection, that appears in all four Gospels. John uses it as a sign pointing to Jesus himself. The long discourse that follows is one of the most challenging in the Gospel, and it ends with a crisis of belief.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Jesus then took the loaves, and when he had given thanks, he distributed them to those who were seated" (6:11).
2. "It is I; do not be afraid" (6:20).
3. "This is the work of God, that you believe in him whom he has sent" (6:29).
4. "I am the bread of life; whoever comes to me shall not hunger, and whoever believes in me shall never thirst" (6:35).
5. "All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out" (6:37).
6. "No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him. And I will raise him up on the last day" (6:44).

7. “Unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you” (6:53).

8. “Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life” (6:68).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus tests Philip with a question about where to buy bread for the crowd. Andrew finds a boy with five barley loaves and two fish. Jesus gives thanks, distributes the food, and everyone eats their fill, with twelve baskets left over. The crowd wants to make him king by force, and he withdraws. That night he walks on the sea to the disciples in the storm, saying, “It is I; do not be afraid.” The Greek is “I am,” the divine name.

The crowd finds him the next day, looking for more bread. He says, “You are seeking me, not because you saw signs, but because you ate your fill.” They ask what work they must do, and he says that the work of God is to believe in the one he sent. They ask for a sign like the manna that Moses gave. Jesus says the true bread from heaven is a person: “I am the bread of life.” The one who comes to him will never hunger, and the one who believes will never thirst.

Then he speaks of the Father’s work. “All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out.” Here is the double truth of salvation. The Father gives, and the Son receives. Everyone given will come, and no one who comes will be turned away. “No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him.” Salvation begins with God. And yet the invitation is real: “whoever comes.” Reformed Christians have found in this chapter a clear statement of God’s sovereign grace, and all Christians find in it a promise that Jesus will not reject anyone who comes.

The talk of eating his flesh and drinking his blood scandalizes the crowd. Jesus is speaking of feeding on him by faith, as the following verses make clear: “It is the Spirit who gives life; the flesh is no help.” Christians have also seen in these words a connection to the Lord’s Supper. Many disciples turn back and no longer walk with him. Jesus asks the Twelve, “Do you want to go away also?” Peter answers for them: “Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life, and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God.” Peter does not understand everything, but he knows there is no one else.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 16 is the manna in the wilderness. Psalm 78:24-25 speaks of the bread of heaven. Isaiah 55:1-3 invites the hungry to come and eat. Deuteronomy 8:3 says man does not live by bread alone. Matthew 14:13-33 is the parallel to the feeding and the walk on water. 1

Corinthians 10:16-17 and 11:23-26 speak of the bread of the Lord's Supper. Ephesians 1:4-5 and Romans 8:29-30 speak of God's choosing.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you are hungry for. Are you coming to Jesus for his gifts or for himself?

Rest in verse 37: if you have come to Jesus, he will never cast you out.

When doctrine is hard, say Peter's words: "Lord, to whom shall we go?"

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus what you hunger for, and thank him that he is the bread of life.
- Thank him that whoever comes to him he will never cast out.
- Ask him to keep you from turning away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

DAY 646 · WEEK 93

John 7:1-8:11

At the Feast of Booths; the woman caught in adultery

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 7:1-8:11. Jesus teaches at the Feast of Booths amid confusion about who he is, and then a woman caught in adultery is brought to him. A note: the story in 7:53-8:11 is not found in the earliest manuscripts, and many translations set it apart. It is widely accepted as an authentic account of Jesus, though scholars differ on whether John wrote it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Feast of Booths was a joyful autumn festival that remembered the wilderness wanderings. Each day a priest drew water from the pool of Siloam and poured it at the altar, and lamps lit up the temple courts. Against this background, Jesus stands on the last and greatest day and offers living water. The crowd is divided. The leaders are looking for a way to arrest him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “If anyone’s will is to do God’s will, he will know whether the teaching is from God or whether I am speaking on my own authority” (7:17).
2. “So they were seeking to arrest him, but no one laid a hand on him, because his hour had not yet come” (7:30).
3. “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (7:37).
4. “Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, Out of his heart will flow rivers of living water” (7:38).
5. “No one ever spoke like this man!” (7:46).

6. “Let him who is without sin among you be the first to throw a stone at her” (8:7).
7. “Woman, where are they? Has no one condemned you?” (8:10).
8. “Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more” (8:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus’ brothers urge him to go to Judea and show himself, but they do not believe in him. He says his time has not yet come, and goes up privately. At the feast, people debate. Some say he is a good man; others say he is leading the people astray. In the middle of the feast, he teaches in the temple. “My teaching is not mine, but his who sent me.” And he gives a principle for judging truth: if anyone is willing to do God’s will, he will know.

On the last day of the feast, when the water ceremony had ended, Jesus cries out, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink.” John explains that he spoke about the Spirit, whom believers would receive after Jesus was glorified. The temple guards come back empty-handed, saying, “No one ever spoke like this man!” Nicodemus, who first came by night, speaks up for fairness.

Then the scene changes. The scribes and Pharisees bring a woman caught in adultery and set her before Jesus, quoting the law of Moses that she should be stoned. It is a trap: if he says to release her, he disregards the law, and if he says to stone her, he loses his reputation for mercy and contradicts Roman law. Jesus stoops and writes on the ground. When they keep asking, he says, “Let him who is without sin among you be the first to throw a stone at her.” One by one, beginning with the oldest, they go away. Jesus is left alone with the woman. “Has no one condemned you?” “No one, Lord.” “Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more.”

Notice the order. Jesus does not say, “Go and sin no more, and then I will not condemn you.” He says he does not condemn, and then calls her to a new life. Grace comes first and makes obedience possible. And Jesus can say this because he is the one who will bear her condemnation on the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 23:33-43 describes the Feast of Booths. Isaiah 12:3 and Zechariah 14:8, 16-19 connect living water and the feast to the age to come. Isaiah 44:3 promises the Spirit poured out on the thirsty. Deuteronomy 17:6-7 and Leviticus 20:10 relate to the case of adultery. Romans 8:1 says there is now no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus. Romans 3:23-24 says all have sinned and are justified by grace. Hebrews 4:15-16 speaks of our sympathetic high priest.

STEP 6

Application

If you are thirsty, go to Jesus and drink. Tell him what you are thirsting for.

Put down any stones you are holding against others. Remember your own sin.

Hear “Neither do I condemn you” as spoken to you, and then ask what “go and sin no more” looks like for you today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Come to Jesus thirsty, and tell him what you thirst for.
- Ask him to pour out his Spirit like rivers of living water.
- Thank him for his compassion for the woman caught in sin.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

“I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.”

JOHN 8:12

DAY 647 · WEEK 93

John 8:12-59

"I AM the light of the world"; before Abraham was, I AM

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 8:12-59. Jesus declares himself the light of the world and argues with the leaders about freedom, fatherhood, and Abraham. It ends with the strongest claim to deity in the Gospel. Notice the "I AM" in verse 58.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The conflict at the Feast of Booths continues. The lamps in the temple courts would have been burning, and Jesus calls himself the light of the world. The discussion that follows grows heated, with the Jews claiming to be Abraham's children and free, and Jesus pointing out that they are slaves to sin. It ends with Jesus saying the divine name over himself, and the crowd picking up stones.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life" (8:12).
2. "And you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free" (8:32).
3. "Truly, truly, I say to you, everyone who practices sin is a slave to sin" (8:34).
4. "So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed" (8:36).
5. "You are of your father the devil, and your will is to do your father's desires" (8:44).
6. "Your father Abraham rejoiced that he would see my day. He saw it and was glad" (8:56).
7. "Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am" (8:58).
8. "So they picked up stones to throw at him, but Jesus hid himself and went out of the temple" (8:59).

STEP 4

Interpretation

"I am the light of the world." This is the second of John's seven "I AM" statements (after the bread of life). The Old Testament pictures God as light, and as the one who led Israel with a pillar of fire. Whoever follows Jesus will not walk in darkness but will have the light of life. The Pharisees object that Jesus is bearing witness about himself, and he answers that his Father also bears witness.

Then he says, "You will die in your sins unless you believe that I am he." This is the first of several uses of "I am" in the chapter. To the believers among them, he says, "If you abide in my word, you are truly my disciples, and you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free." The Jews bristle: we are Abraham's offspring and have never been enslaved. Jesus replies that everyone who sins is a slave to sin, and that only the Son can set them free. Freedom comes only from him.

The argument escalates. They claim Abraham as their father, and Jesus tells them Abraham would not have acted as they do. They claim God as their father, and Jesus says that if God were their Father, they would love him. Instead they are acting like the devil, who was a murderer from the beginning and a liar. These are harsh words, spoken to those who were trying to kill him.

Finally, they ask, "Are you greater than our father Abraham?" Jesus replies, "Your father Abraham rejoiced that he would see my day." They are incredulous: "You are not yet fifty years old, and have you seen Abraham?" Then comes the verse: "Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am." He does not say "I was." He uses the divine name from Exodus 3:14. The leaders understand exactly what he is claiming, and they pick up stones. It is blasphemy unless it is true.

The chapter shows that the issue is not just Jesus' teaching but his identity. If he is the eternal I AM, then he is the light, the truth, and the one who can set us free.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 3:14 is God's name, I AM. Isaiah 41:4 and 43:10-13 also use "I am he." Psalm 27:1 says the LORD is my light. Isaiah 9:2 and 60:1-3 promise light to those in darkness. John 1:4-9 says the Word is the light. Romans 6:16-18 explains slavery to sin and freedom in Christ. Galatians 5:1 says for freedom Christ has set us free. Hebrews 11:13 says the patriarchs saw the promises from afar. 1 John 1:5-7 says God is light.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you still walk in darkness. Bring that area to Jesus, the light.

What are you enslaved to? Bring it to the Son, who makes you free indeed.

Pray, “Jesus, you are the I AM,” and let the weight of that rest on you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus you want to follow the light of the world.
- Ask him to set you free from sin by his truth.
- Worship him as the great I AM.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

“I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.”

JOHN 8:12

DAY 648 · WEEK 93

Psalm 119:97-120

Oh how I love your law; your word is a lamp

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:97-120. This section of the great psalm on God's word speaks of love for the law, sweetness, and light for the path. Read verse 105 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible, an acrostic of twenty-two stanzas, each beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. In this plan, it is spread across several days. Today's reading covers three stanzas, Mem, Nun, and Samekh, and speaks of the power of God's word. Jesus said that his word would make us free, and this psalm shows the heart that treasures it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day" (v. 97).
2. "Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is ever with me" (v. 98).
3. "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (v. 103).
4. "Through your precepts I get understanding; therefore I hate every false way" (v. 104).
5. "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" (v. 105).
6. "You are my hiding place and my shield; I hope in your word" (v. 114).
7. "Hold me up, that I may be safe and have regard for your statutes continually!" (v. 117).
8. "My flesh trembles for fear of you, and I am afraid of your judgments" (v. 120).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The stanza called Mem begins with an exclamation of love: “Oh how I love your law!” The psalmist is not describing a duty but a delight. He meditates on God’s word all day, and it makes him wiser than his enemies, wiser than his teachers, and wiser than the aged. It gives him wisdom because it comes from God and it shapes his conduct. He keeps his feet from every evil way. Then comes the sweetness: “How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!”

The next stanza, Nun, begins with the best-known line: “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.” A lamp in the ancient world did not light up the whole road. It showed the next step. God’s word may not tell us everything about the future, but it shows us enough to take the next step. The psalmist has sworn to keep God’s righteous rules, and he is deeply afflicted, yet he says, “Give me life, O LORD, according to your word.” The word is both light and life. He asks that the LORD accept his freewill offerings of praise, and says that God’s testimonies are the joy of his heart.

In Samekh, the psalmist hates the double-minded and loves God’s law. “You are my hiding place and my shield; I hope in your word.” Here the word is not just a lamp but a shelter. He asks for help to keep the commandments and for God to uphold him: “Hold me up, that I may be safe.” He knows that on his own he cannot stand. The stanza ends with fear and trembling: “My flesh trembles for fear of you.” A right fear of God does not exclude love; it deepens it.

In John, Jesus is the Word, and he said, “If you abide in my word, you are truly my disciples.” To love God’s word is to love him. Jesus Christ fulfilled the law the psalmist loved, and the Spirit he sends writes it on our hearts.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 1:2 and 19:7-11 also praise the delight of the law. Joshua 1:8 commands meditation on the book of the law. Jeremiah 15:16 says your words became to me a joy. Matthew 4:4 quotes Deuteronomy 8:3, that man lives by every word from God’s mouth. John 8:31-32 and 17:17 speak of the truth of the word. 2 Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is breathed out by God. Hebrews 4:12 says the word of God is living and active.

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 105 aloud and ask what the next step is for you. Where do you need light?

Choose a short passage and meditate on it throughout the day, as verse 97 describes.

Ask God to make his word sweeter to you than honey. Pray it honestly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you love about his law.
- Ask him to let it be your meditation all the day.
- Ask him to light your path with it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

DAY 649 · WEEK 93

Psalm 43

Send out your light and your truth

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 43. It is a short prayer from someone in darkness, asking for God's light and truth to lead him to worship. It pairs with Psalm 42, and it ends with a refrain of hope.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 43 has no title and was likely the last stanza of Psalm 42, since they share the same refrain: "Why are you cast down, O my soul?" The singer is far from the temple, mocked by enemies and deeply discouraged. His prayer is for God to send light and truth to bring him back to worship. It follows Psalm 119 and John 8 in the theme of light and truth.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Vindicate me, O God" (v. 1).
2. "You are the God in whom I take refuge" (v. 2).
3. "Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?" (v. 2).
4. "Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me" (v. 3).
5. "Let them bring me to your holy hill and to your dwelling!" (v. 3).
6. "To God my exceeding joy" (v. 4).
7. "Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me?" (v. 5).
8. "Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a legal appeal. The singer asks God to vindicate him and defend his cause against a people who are deceitful and unjust. Then he turns to a question that many believers have asked: “For you are the God in whom I take refuge; why have you rejected me?” He is confused. God is his refuge, and yet he feels abandoned. “Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?” The psalm lets us ask hard questions.

The center of the prayer is verse 3: “Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me.” He does not ask for an explanation of why he is suffering. He asks for light and truth, as if they were two guides sent from God. Light shows the path. Truth keeps him from deception. Together they will lead him to the holy hill and to God’s dwelling, where he can worship. John 1 and 14 tell us who God sent: Jesus is the light of the world, and he is the truth. He leads us to the Father.

The goal is worship: “Then I will go to the altar of God, to God my exceeding joy.” What he longs for is not just relief from his enemies but God himself. God is his exceeding joy. Then he will praise God with the lyre.

The psalm ends with a conversation with himself. “Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me?” He does not deny his feelings. He questions them. And he answers: “Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God.” Notice the word “again.” He is not praising now, but he knows he will. Depression and discouragement are real, and God’s people are not exempt, but they are not the last word. Our hope is in the God who will bring light.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 42 shares the refrain. Psalm 27:1 and 36:9 speak of the LORD as light. Psalm 119:105 calls the word a lamp. John 1:9, 8:12, and 14:6 apply light and truth to Jesus. Lamentations 3:21-26 teaches hope in the LORD in the midst of grief. Romans 15:13 prays that the God of hope would fill you with joy and peace. 2 Corinthians 4:8-9 says we are afflicted but not crushed.

STEP 6

Application

When you are cast down, speak to your soul as the psalmist did. Say, “Hope in God.”

Pray verse 3 as a prayer for guidance: “Send out your light and your truth.”

Tell a trusted friend honestly if you are struggling. You do not need to carry it alone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you feel forgotten.
- Ask him to send out his light and truth.
- Tell your soul to hope in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

DAY 650 · WEEK 93

John 9:1-10:21

The man born blind; the Good Shepherd

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 9:1-10:21. Jesus heals a man born blind, the Pharisees interrogate him, and Jesus then speaks of himself as the door and the good shepherd. Follow the blind man's growth from not knowing, to knowing, to worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Still in Jerusalem, Jesus passes a man who has been blind from birth. The disciples ask whose sin caused it, a common assumption. Jesus gives another answer. What follows is a masterpiece of storytelling: the healing, a series of interrogations, and the man's confession. It leads into Jesus' words about the sheep and the shepherd, which echo Ezekiel 34, where God promises to shepherd his scattered flock.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It was not that this man sinned, or his parents, but that the works of God might be displayed in him" (9:3).
2. "One thing I do know, that though I was blind, now I see" (9:25).
3. "For judgment I came into this world, that those who do not see may see, and those who see may become blind" (9:39).
4. "I am the door. If anyone enters by me, he will be saved and will go in and out and find pasture" (10:9).
5. "I came that they may have life and have it abundantly" (10:10).
6. "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep" (10:11).
7. "So there will be one flock, one shepherd" (10:16).

8 “No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord” (10:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus rejects the idea that this man’s blindness was the direct result of someone’s sin. It was so that the works of God might be displayed in him. He spits on the ground, makes mud, anoints the man’s eyes, and tells him to wash in the pool of Siloam. The man goes, washes, and returns seeing.

The neighbors can hardly believe it, and the Pharisees investigate. It was the Sabbath again. The man’s answers grow bolder at each stage. First: “The man called Jesus made mud.” Then: “He is a prophet.” When the leaders press him, he says, “One thing I do know, that though I was blind, now I see.” He cannot explain everything, but he knows what happened. They mock him, and he says, with a touch of irony, “Do you also want to become his disciples?” They throw him out. Jesus finds him and asks, “Do you believe in the Son of Man?” “Lord, I believe,” he says, and worships. The blind man sees, and those who claim to see remain blind.

Jesus then turns to the image of the sheep. The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. Jesus has come that his sheep may have life and have it abundantly. He is the door: whoever enters through him will be saved. He is also the good shepherd, who knows his sheep by name, and whom the sheep know. The hired hand flees when the wolf comes, but the shepherd lays down his life for the sheep.

Notice the contrast. The false shepherds, the religious leaders who cast out the blind man, care for themselves. Jesus, the true shepherd, seeks the outcast. He says he has other sheep who are not of this fold, a reference to the Gentiles, and “there will be one flock, one shepherd.” And his death is no accident: “No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have authority to lay it down, and authority to take it up again.”

The Father’s command and the Son’s authority are in harmony. The shepherd dies willingly, and rises. The people divide again over his words. This is the third and fourth of the “I AM” sayings, the door and the good shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34 are the great shepherd passages. Isaiah 35:5 and 42:7 promise sight for the blind. Isaiah 42:16 says God will lead the blind in a way they do not know. Jeremiah 23:1-4 condemns false shepherds. Zechariah 11 pictures the rejected shepherd. 1 Peter 2:25 says we have returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of our souls. Hebrews 13:20 calls Jesus the great shepherd of the sheep. Revelation 7:17 says the Lamb will be their shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Tell someone your own “I was blind, but now I see” in a sentence or two.

Listen for the shepherd’s voice in his word today. What is he saying to you?

Pray for someone who has been cast out or hurt by the church. Ask Jesus to find them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus, “I was blind, and now I see,” and name something he has shown you.
- Ask him to help you hear the Shepherd’s voice.
- Worship him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

“I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.”

JOHN 8:12

DAY 651 · WEEK 93

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 8:12 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this in the temple courts during the Feast of Booths, when the great lamps were lit. It is one of the seven great "I AM" statements of John's Gospel.

"I am the light of the world." The claim is huge. Not a light, but the light. Not of Israel only, but of the world. In the Bible, light is the first thing God created, and it is a picture of his holiness, truth, and life. Jesus says he is that light in person.

"Whoever follows me." Light is for walking by. It is not enough to admire it. Following means putting one foot in front of the other behind him, trusting him with the path.

"Will not walk in darkness." Darkness means sin, ignorance, and death. The one who follows Jesus is not left to stumble. Even when the path is hard, he is not lost.

"But will have the light of life." He will not only see by the light, he will have it, as his own possession. The light is life itself. Jesus does not just show the way; he gives life.

When you feel confused or lost, say this verse. He is the light, and you do not have to find the way alone.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week Jesus fed five thousand and declared himself the bread of life, and you heard Peter say, “To whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life.” At the Feast of Booths he offered living water and said, “Neither do I condemn you” to a woman caught in sin. He declared himself the light of the world, promised that the Son sets us free indeed, and used the divine name of himself: “Before Abraham was, I am.” In the Psalms you read about delighting in God’s word as a lamp for your feet (Psalm 119), and you prayed for light and truth to lead you out of discouragement (Psalm 43). In John 9 and 10 you watched a blind man receive sight and worship, and heard Jesus say that he is the door and the good shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said, “I am the bread of life.” What do you tend to hunger for in place of him, and what would it mean to feed on him this week?

The woman caught in adultery heard, “Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more.” How does the order, grace first and then a call to change, shape how you deal with your own sin?

Jesus is the good shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep. What does it mean for you personally that he knows you by name?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being the light, the bread, the door, and the good shepherd.

Tell him which of these you most need today.

Rest in him.

DAY 652 · WEEK 94

John 10:22-11:57

I and the Father are one; Lazarus raised

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 10:22-11:57. Jesus declares that he and the Father are one, and then raises Lazarus from the dead. Notice how the raising of Lazarus both displays his glory and sets his death in motion.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is winter, at the Feast of Dedication (Hanukkah), which celebrated the cleansing of the temple. The Jews press Jesus to say plainly whether he is the Christ. His answer leads to a second attempt to stone him. He withdraws across the Jordan, and then receives word that his friend Lazarus, in Bethany near Jerusalem, is sick. The seventh and greatest sign in John's Gospel follows.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me" (10:27).
2. "I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand" (10:28).
3. "I and the Father are one" (10:30).
4. "I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live" (11:25).
5. "Jesus wept" (11:35).
6. "Lazarus, come out" (11:43).
7. "Unbind him, and let him go" (11:44).

8 “It is better for you that one man should die for the people, not that the whole nation should perish” (11:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“If you are the Christ, tell us plainly,” they say. Jesus replies that he has told them, and his works testify, but they do not believe because they are not among his sheep. Then he gives some of the most comforting words in the Bible. His sheep hear his voice. He knows them, and they follow him. He gives them eternal life. They will never perish, and no one can snatch them out of his hand. Then he says the Father’s hand holds them too: “No one is able to snatch them out of the Father’s hand.” This is the security of every believer. Salvation is held by God, not by the strength of our grip. And then: “I and the Father are one.” The Jews pick up stones, for they understand he is claiming to be God.

When word comes that Lazarus is ill, Jesus waits two more days. This looks like neglect, but he explains that the illness is for the glory of God. When he arrives, Lazarus has been dead four days. Martha meets him and says, “Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died.” Jesus says, “Your brother will rise again.” She believes in the resurrection at the last day. Then Jesus says, “I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live, and everyone who lives and believes in me shall never die.” He asks, “Do you believe this?” Martha answers with one of the great confessions: “Yes, Lord; I believe that you are the Christ, the Son of God.”

When Mary comes weeping, Jesus is deeply moved in spirit and troubled. Then comes the shortest verse in the English Bible: “Jesus wept.” The Son of God, who knows he is about to raise Lazarus, weeps with those who weep. He is not distant from our grief. At the tomb he prays aloud for the sake of the crowd and cries, “Lazarus, come out!” The dead man comes out, bound in grave clothes. “Unbind him, and let him go.”

The sign brings belief to many, but the chief priests and Pharisees decide that Jesus must die. Caiaphas, the high priest, says unwittingly that it is better for one man to die for the people. John comments that he prophesied that Jesus would die for the nation, and to gather into one the children of God who are scattered abroad. The miracle that gave life to Lazarus will lead to the death of Jesus. The giver of life gives his own.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34 are the background to the sheep imagery. Isaiah 25:8 promises that God will swallow up death forever. Daniel 12:2 speaks of those who sleep in the dust awakening. Hosea 13:14 says God will ransom them from the power of Sheol. 1 Corinthians

15:20-26 speaks of Christ's resurrection as the firstfruits. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts those grieving believers. Romans 8:35-39 speaks of the security of those loved by Christ. Hebrews 4:15 says we have a high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses.

STEP 6

Application

Rest in verses 28 and 29. Your salvation is held in the hands of Christ and the Father.

Bring your grief to Jesus, who wept. Tell him what you have lost.

Ask Martha's question of yourself: "Do you believe this?" Answer it in your own words.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that no one can snatch you from his hand.
- Ask him to help you hear his voice.
- Thank him that he and the Father are one.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 653 · WEEK 94

John 12:1-50

The anointing; the Entry; the grain of wheat must die

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 12:1-50. Mary anoints Jesus, the crowds welcome him into Jerusalem, Greeks seek him, and he speaks of the grain of wheat that must die. The first half of John's Gospel ends here. Read verses 23 to 33 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Six days before Passover, Jesus returns to Bethany for a supper in his honor. Lazarus is at the table. Large crowds come to see both Jesus and Lazarus, and many are believing. Meanwhile the chief priests plot to kill Lazarus as well. Jesus enters Jerusalem to the shouts of the crowd. Then the "hour" that has been mentioned throughout the Gospel finally arrives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Mary therefore took a pound of expensive ointment made from pure nard, and anointed the feet of Jesus and wiped his feet with her hair. The house was filled with the fragrance of the perfume" (12:3).
2. "Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord, even the King of Israel!" (12:13).
3. "Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit" (12:24).
4. "Whoever loves his life loses it, and whoever hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life" (12:25).
5. "And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself" (12:32).

6. “They loved the glory that comes from man more than the glory that comes from God” (12:43).
7. “I have come into the world as light, so that whoever believes in me may not remain in darkness” (12:46).
8. “For I did not come to judge the world but to save the world” (12:47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At the supper, Mary takes a pound of costly perfume, pours it on Jesus’ feet, and wipes them with her hair. The house fills with the fragrance. Judas objects, saying it should have been sold and given to the poor, though John says he was a thief. Jesus defends her: “Leave her alone, so that she may keep it for the day of my burial.” She gives extravagantly, and Jesus accepts it as worship.

The next day, a large crowd takes palm branches and goes out to meet him, shouting “Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord, even the King of Israel!” Jesus sits on a young donkey, as Zechariah foretold. The Pharisees say, “Look, the world has gone after him.”

Some Greeks, Gentiles who had come to worship at the feast, ask to see Jesus. When Philip and Andrew tell him, Jesus says, “The hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified.” The hour he has been waiting for is here, and it is tied to the coming of the nations. Then he says, “Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit.” His death will not end his work but multiply it. And the principle applies to his followers: “Whoever loves his life loses it.”

Jesus is troubled: “Now is my soul troubled. And what shall I say? Father, save me from this hour? But for this purpose I have come to this hour. Father, glorify your name.” A voice from heaven answers. Then he says, “And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself.” John explains that he said this to show by what kind of death he was going to die. The cross is the throne, and from it he draws people of every nation.

John closes the first half of the Gospel with a sad note. Despite so many signs, they did not believe, and John quotes Isaiah on hardness of heart. Some leaders believed but would not confess, “for they loved the glory that comes from man more than the glory that comes from God.” Jesus cries out once more: he has come as light, to save and not to judge.

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 is the donkey. Psalm 118:25-26 is the hosanna. Isaiah 53:1 and 6:10 are quoted at the end. Numbers 21:8-9 is the lifted bronze serpent. Genesis 12:3 promised the blessing to all nations. Galatians 2:20 says we have been crucified with Christ. Philippians 3:7-8 counts everything as loss for the sake of Christ. Mark 14:3-9 and Matthew 26:6-13 tell the story of the anointing.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what extravagant act of love you might offer Jesus, in time or money or service.

Consider what it means for you to "die" like the grain of wheat: what are you holding that needs to fall into the earth?

Pray for the nations: that the Greeks of our day would see Jesus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you pour out your best on Jesus, as Mary did.
- Ask him to teach you what it means to die like the grain of wheat.
- Tell him what you want to lay down.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 654 · WEEK 94

John 13:1-14:31

The foot washing; "I AM the way"; the Spirit promised

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 13:1-14:31. The Upper Room begins: Jesus washes his disciples' feet, gives a new commandment, predicts betrayal and denial, and then comforts them with promises of the Father's house, the Way, and the Holy Spirit. Take your time. These are among the most tender chapters in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is the night before Jesus' death. He is in an upper room in Jerusalem with the Twelve. John spends five chapters (13 to 17) on this one evening, and he omits the Lord's Supper itself. The tone shifts: no more public debates, only a Teacher preparing his friends for his departure. Judas leaves early, and in the darkness Jesus says words of great love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end" (13:1).
2. "If I then, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another's feet" (13:14).
3. "A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another" (13:34).
4. "By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another" (13:35).
5. "Let not your hearts be troubled. Believe in God; believe also in me" (14:1).
6. "I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me" (14:6).

7. “And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever” (14:16).

8. “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you. Not as the world gives do I give to you” (14:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“Having loved his own… he loved them to the end.” Jesus rises from supper, takes off his outer garments, and wraps a towel around his waist. He pours water into a basin and begins to wash the disciples’ feet, a task for the lowest servant. Peter objects: “You shall never wash my feet.” Jesus replies, “If I do not wash you, you have no share with me.” The washing points to the cleansing that Jesus will accomplish on the cross. Then he explains the example: “If I then, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another’s feet.” The King serves.

He predicts that one of them will betray him. Judas leaves, and John says, “And it was night.” Jesus then says, “Now is the Son of Man glorified.” He gives the new commandment: love one another as I have loved you. Love is the badge of discipleship. Peter declares that he will lay down his life for Jesus, and Jesus answers that he will deny him three times.

Chapter 14 opens with comfort. “Let not your hearts be troubled.” He is going to prepare a place in his Father’s house, which has many rooms, and he will come again and take them to himself. Thomas objects, “We do not know where you are going. How can we know the way?” Jesus replies with the sixth “I AM”: “I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.” This is the exclusive claim of the gospel and also a great invitation. The way is a person, and he is available to anyone who comes.

Philip asks, “Show us the Father.” Jesus says, “Whoever has seen me has seen the Father.” Then comes the promise of the Spirit. Jesus will ask the Father, and he will give another Helper, the Spirit of truth, who dwells with them and will be in them. “I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you.” The Spirit will teach them and remind them of all that Jesus said. Finally: “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you.” He leaves them not with an escape from trouble but with his peace.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 is the Passover context of the meal. Isaiah 52:13 and 53:11-12 describe the suffering servant. Psalm 41:9 predicts the betrayal. Leviticus 19:18 is the old love commandment. Isaiah 43:1-2 promises the presence of God in trouble. Ezekiel 36:27

promised the Spirit within. Acts 2 records the coming of the Spirit. Philippians 2:5-8 shows the same servant attitude. 1 John 3:16 and 4:7-12 build on the new commandment.

STEP 6

Application

Find a way to serve someone this week in a hidden, humble way, like washing feet.

Say verse 1 to yourself when you are anxious, and name what troubles your heart.

Thank the Father for Jesus, the way, the truth, and the life. Pray for someone who does not yet know him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for loving you to the end and washing feet.
- Ask him to teach you to serve.
- Ask him to help you love others as he has loved you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 655 · WEEK 94

Psalm 23

The LORD is my shepherd

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 23. This is the best known of all the psalms. Read it slowly, as though for the first time, and hear Jesus say, “I am the good shepherd.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 23 is a psalm of David, who had been a shepherd. He knew what it was to guard sheep from lions and bears, to lead them to water, to count them at night. Here he uses that experience to describe the LORD’s care for him. The psalm moves from the pasture to the valley to the banquet table to the house of the LORD. It follows the good shepherd of John 10.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want” (v. 1).
2. “He makes me lie down in green pastures” (v. 2).
3. “He leads me beside still waters” (v. 2).
4. “He restores my soul” (v. 3).
5. “He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name’s sake” (v. 3).
6. “Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me” (v. 4).
7. “You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies; you anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows” (v. 5).
8. “Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life, and I shall dwell in the house of the LORD forever” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

"The LORD is my shepherd." This is the foundation. The covenant name of God, Yahweh, is joined with a word of personal care. He is not just the shepherd of Israel in general; he is mine. "I shall not want" means that under his care nothing essential will be lacking.

The first scene is the pasture. A sheep will not lie down unless it is free from fear, from hunger, from friction in the flock, and from pests. The shepherd must provide all of this. "He makes me lie down in green pastures. He leads me beside still waters." He restores my soul, meaning he brings me back when I wander, and renews me. He leads me in paths of righteousness, not because I deserve it but "for his name's sake." His reputation is bound up with his flock.

The scene shifts to the valley. "Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death." The path to the good pasture often goes through dark ravines. David does not say if, but "though." And notice the change from "he" to "you" in the middle of the psalm. When the danger is greatest, David speaks directly to the shepherd: "for you are with me." The rod fights off predators and the staff guides and rescues. They comfort him.

Then the picture changes to a banquet. The host prepares a table in the presence of enemies. They cannot touch him. He anoints his guest's head with oil, and the cup overflows. The shepherd is also a host.

The psalm ends in hope: "Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life." The word translated "follow" is a strong word, like pursuing. God's goodness and steadfast love chase after us. And the destination is secure: "I shall dwell in the house of the LORD forever."

Jesus said, "I am the good shepherd." He is the one who leads, protects, and dies for the sheep. The 23rd Psalm is fulfilled in him.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 48:15 and 49:24 call God the shepherd of his people. Ezekiel 34:11-16 promises that God himself will seek and shepherd his sheep. Isaiah 40:11 pictures God gathering lambs in his arms. John 10:11-16, Hebrews 13:20, and 1 Peter 5:4 identify Jesus as the shepherd. Revelation 7:15-17 says the Lamb will be their shepherd and wipe away every tear. Psalm 16:11 and 27:4 speak of dwelling in his presence.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud, putting your own name in: “The LORD is my shepherd, and I shall not want.”

Identify your valley right now. Say verse 4 to the Shepherd.

Memorize the psalm if you have not already. It will be with you in dark times.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you lack and what you want him to shepherd.
- Tell him about your valley, and that you are with him there.
- Thank him for goodness and mercy following you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

“I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.”

JOHN 14:6

DAY 656 · WEEK 94

Psalm 100

We are his people and the sheep of his pasture

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 100. It is a short psalm of thanksgiving, a call to the whole earth to come to the LORD with gladness. Read it aloud, as if you were entering the temple gates.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 100 is titled "A Psalm for giving thanks." It was probably sung by pilgrims as they entered the temple courts. It has a simple structure: two calls to worship (vv. 1 to 2 and 4), each followed by a reason (vv. 3 and 5). It has been sung for centuries by the church. It follows Psalm 23 with the same image of the flock.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Serve the LORD with gladness!" (v. 2).
3. "Come into his presence with singing!" (v. 2).
4. "Know that the LORD, he is God!" (v. 3).
5. "It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture" (v. 3).
6. "Enter his gates with thanksgiving, and his courts with praise!" (v. 4).
7. "Give thanks to him; bless his name!" (v. 4).
8. "For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a command to all the earth, not just Israel: make a joyful noise. Worship is not meant to be grim. “Serve the LORD with gladness! Come into his presence with singing!” Service and joy go together. The word for serve is the word for work or worship, and it is to be done gladly.

Then comes the foundation: “Know that the LORD, he is God!” All true worship begins with knowing who God is. He is the LORD, the covenant God. “It is he who made us, and we are his.” We did not make ourselves, and we belong to him. “We are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.” The shepherd image returns. We are not self-made or self-sufficient. We are creatures and sheep, cared for by the Maker.

The second call is to enter his gates with thanksgiving and his courts with praise. Gratitude is the doorway to worship. We come not because we have earned entry, but because we have been invited. “Give thanks to him; bless his name!”

And the second reason is a threefold description of God: “For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations.” Good describes his nature. Steadfast love describes his covenant commitment. Faithfulness describes his reliability across generations. This does not change. The generations before us trusted this God, and the generations after us will be able to.

The psalm is the response of the redeemed. In Christ, the invitation to the nations is extended to the world, and the flock is gathered from all peoples. The sheep of his pasture are those who hear his voice. John 10 says there will be one flock and one shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 95 is a similar call to worship. Psalm 117 invites all nations. Psalm 136 repeats “for his steadfast love endures forever.” Ezekiel 34:30-31 says the sheep are God’s people. Colossians 3:15-17 calls for thankfulness and singing. Hebrews 13:15 speaks of a sacrifice of praise. Revelation 7:9-12 pictures the nations praising God.

STEP 6

Application

Begin today with gladness. Give thanks for three things before you do anything else.

Sing a song of praise, or play one, and sing along.

Thank God for his faithfulness to your family, in the past and now.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Make a joyful noise to God, in your own words.
- Thank him that you are his people and the sheep of his pasture.
- Serve him with gladness today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 657 · WEEK 94

Psalm 103

Bless the LORD, O my soul

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 103. It is one of the most beloved psalms of praise. David speaks to his own soul, and recounts the benefits of God: forgiveness, healing, redemption, and compassion. Read it slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 103 is a psalm of David. It opens with a self-address: "Bless the LORD, O my soul." Then it moves through a list of God's benefits, his character, his compassion for human weakness, and his everlasting throne. It ends with a call to the angels and all creation to bless him. Reading it after John 13 to 14 makes us see the love of the Father which Jesus came to show.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bless the LORD, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name!" (v. 1).
2. "Who forgives all your iniquity, who heals all your diseases" (v. 3).
3. "The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love" (v. 8).
4. "He does not deal with us according to our sins, nor repay us according to our iniquities" (v. 10).
5. "As far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us" (v. 12).
6. "As a father shows compassion to his children, so the LORD shows compassion to those who fear him" (v. 13).
7. "For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust" (v. 14).

8 “But the steadfast love of the LORD is from everlasting to everlasting on those who fear him” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David talks to himself. “Bless the LORD, O my soul, and all that is within me.” He gathers up his whole being, mind, heart, and will, to praise. And he reminds himself not to forget God’s benefits. We tend to forget. The list begins with the greatest: God forgives all our iniquity. He heals all our diseases. He redeems our life from the pit. He crowns us with steadfast love and mercy. He satisfies us with good, so that our youth is renewed like the eagle’s.

Verse 8 is a quotation of what God said to Moses on Sinai: “merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love.” It is the heart of the Old Testament’s picture of God. He does not always accuse or keep his anger forever. “He does not deal with us according to our sins.” If he did, none of us would survive. Instead, as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his steadfast love toward those who fear him. “As far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us.” East and west never meet. Our sins are gone.

Then comes the tender image of a father: “As a father shows compassion to his children, so the LORD shows compassion to those who fear him.” Jesus came to reveal the Father in this way. “For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust.” God is not surprised by our weakness. He knows what we are made of. Human life is brief, like grass, but the steadfast love of the LORD is from everlasting to everlasting.

The psalm ends with a widening circle of praise. God’s throne is established in the heavens, and his kingdom rules over all. Angels, mighty ones, hosts, and all his works in all places are called to bless the LORD. And the psalm ends where it began: “Bless the LORD, O my soul!”

How can God forgive sin so completely and still be just? The cross answers that question. The Father removed our transgressions as far as the east is from the west because the Son bore them.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 is the source of verse 8. Isaiah 40:6-8 contrasts the grass with the word of God. Micah 7:18-19 says God casts all our sins into the depths of the sea. Isaiah 38:17 says he has cast all my sins behind his back. Luke 15:20 is the father running to the prodigal. Romans 3:25-26 explains how God is just and the justifier. Ephesians 1:7 says in him we have redemption through his blood. Hebrews 8:12 promises that he will remember our sins no more.

STEP 6

Application

Write a list of God's benefits to you, as David did. Read it aloud and give thanks.

Take a sin you cannot forgive in yourself and place it as far as the east is from the west.

Speak to your own soul: "Bless the LORD, O my soul."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD with all that is within you.

Name a benefit of his that you do not want to forget.

Thank him that he removes your sin as far as the east is from the west.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 658 · WEEK 94

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 14:6 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to Thomas in the upper room, on the last night before the cross. Thomas had asked, "How can we know the way?" and Jesus' answer is not a set of directions but himself.

"I am the way." Jesus is not just a guide who points. He is the road itself. We come to God not by our efforts, rituals, or goodness, but by Jesus. His death opens the path to God.

"And the truth." He is the reality behind all the shadows of the Old Testament, and the truth about God. Everything he says is true because he is truth.

"And the life." He gives life that death cannot end. He is the source of it, the one who raised Lazarus and who rose himself.

"No one comes to the Father except through me." This is exclusive and it is gracious. It is exclusive because there is only one way. It is gracious because the way is open to anyone who comes. No one is turned away.

When you wonder if you are on the right path, or when someone asks how a person can know God, say this verse. The way is a person, and he is here.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week Jesus declared that his sheep will never perish and that no one can snatch them from his hand. You stood at Lazarus's tomb and heard him say, "I am the resurrection and the life." You saw Mary pour out costly perfume and Jesus speak of the grain of wheat that must fall into the earth and die. In the Upper Room, he washed his disciples' feet, gave a new commandment, and comforted them with the promise of the Father's house, the Way, and the Helper. The Psalms were a chorus of the shepherd: Psalm 23, the LORD is my shepherd; Psalm 100, we are the sheep of his pasture; and Psalm 103, bless the LORD, O my soul, who forgives all your iniquity.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said no one can snatch his sheep out of his hand. How does this security affect how you think about doubt and failure?

At the Last Supper, Jesus washed feet and gave a new commandment to love one another. Who is one person you could serve or love this week in a way that costs you something?

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life. What does it mean to you that the way to the Father is a person and not a program?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he is the way, truth, and life.

Thank him that his sheep are safe in his hand.

Rest in the Father's house.

DAY 659 · WEEK 95

John 15:1-16:33

"I AM the vine"; the Paraclete; sorrow turned to joy

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 15:1-16:33. Jesus continues his teaching in the Upper Room: the vine and the branches, the world's hatred, and the work of the Holy Spirit. It ends with sorrow turned to joy and a word of victory. Read 15:1-17 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The disciples have heard that Jesus is going away, and they are troubled. Jesus has told them to love one another and has promised the Spirit. Now, as they leave the upper room (14:31), he continues to teach, perhaps on the way to the garden. The image of the vine was familiar: Israel was often called God's vine in the Old Testament, and was often unfruitful. Jesus says that he is the true vine.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I am the true vine, and my Father is the vinedresser" (15:1).
2. "I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing" (15:5).
3. "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends" (15:13).
4. "You did not choose me, but I chose you and appointed you that you should go and bear fruit" (15:16).
5. "If the world hates you, know that it has hated me before it hated you" (15:18).
6. "It is to your advantage that I go away, for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you" (16:7).

7. “When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth” (16:13).
8. “In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world” (16:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“I am the true vine, and my Father is the vinedresser.” This is the seventh and last of John’s “I AM” statements with a picture. Israel had been the vine that failed to bear good fruit (Isaiah 5), and Jesus is the true Israel who does. The Father is the gardener. He removes the branches that bear no fruit and prunes those that do, so that they bear more. Pruning is painful, but its purpose is fruitfulness.

The key word is “abide.” It means to remain, to stay connected. “Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit by itself, unless it abides in the vine, neither can you, unless you abide in me.” A branch has no life of its own. It lives by being joined to the vine. Apart from Jesus we can do nothing. Abiding in him means trusting him, keeping his words in us, praying, and loving as he loves. The fruit is Christlike character, and also lasting work and joy: “that my joy may be in you, and that your joy may be full.”

The vine teaches about union with Christ, which is at the center of the New Testament. We are not merely following his example; we are joined to him. His life flows into ours. The result is love: “As the Father has loved me, so have I loved you. Abide in my love.” The command is to love one another, and the model is his own sacrifice: “Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends.” He calls them friends, not servants, because he has made known to them all that he has heard from the Father. And in verse 16: “You did not choose me, but I chose you.” The initiative is his.

Then he warns that the world will hate them, as it hated him. Persecution will come. But the Spirit will come as Helper, testify about Jesus, convict the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment, and guide them into all the truth. The disciples are sad that Jesus is leaving, but he says it is to their advantage, because the Spirit will come. He uses the picture of a woman in labor: her pain turns to joy when the child is born. The disciples will weep, but their sorrow will become joy, and no one will take it from them.

The discourse ends with a promise: “In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world.” It is the victory he will win on the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 5:1-7, Psalm 80:8-16, and Hosea 10:1 describe Israel as a vine. Jeremiah 2:21 says Israel became a degenerate wild vine. Ezekiel 15 and 19:10-14 speak of the vine's fruitlessness. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. Romans 6:5 and 11:17-24 speak of being united with Christ and grafted in. Colossians 1:27 speaks of Christ in you, the hope of glory. 1 John 2:6, 3:24, and 4:13 speak of abiding. Philippians 1:6 says God will complete his good work.

STEP 6

Application

Ask how you are abiding: in prayer, in the Word, in fellowship? Choose one practice to strengthen.

Think about a season of pruning in your life. Ask the vinedresser what fruit he is growing.

Say "I have overcome the world" to yourself the next time you are afraid.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you abide in the true vine.
- Confess where you try to produce fruit apart from him.
- Thank him for turning sorrow into joy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 660 · WEEK 95

John 17:1-26

The High Priestly Prayer, "that they may be one"

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 17:1-26. This is the longest prayer of Jesus in the Bible, often called the High Priestly Prayer. He prays for himself, for his disciples, and for all who will believe through their word. You are overhearing the Son pray for you. Read it slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus has finished teaching in the upper room. Before crossing the Kidron valley to the garden, he lifts his eyes to heaven and prays aloud, so that his disciples can hear. The prayer has three parts: for his own glorification (vv. 1 to 5), for the eleven disciples (vv. 6 to 19), and for all future believers (vv. 20 to 26). It is a rare glimpse into the intimate relationship between the Son and the Father, and into what Jesus wants for his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Father, the hour has come; glorify your Son that the Son may glorify you" (17:1).
2. "And this is eternal life, that they know you the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent" (17:3).
3. "I glorified you on earth, having accomplished the work that you gave me to do" (17:4).
4. "I do not ask that you take them out of the world, but that you keep them from the evil one" (17:15).
5. "Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth" (17:17).
6. "That they may all be one, just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, that they also may be in us" (17:21).

7. “Father, I desire that they also, whom you have given me, may be with me where I am, to see my glory” (17:24).

8. “That the love with which you have loved me may be in them, and I in them” (17:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus begins by praying for himself, but his request is that the Son may glorify the Father. He has authority over all flesh so that he may give eternal life to all whom the Father has given him. Then he defines eternal life: “that they know you the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent.” Eternal life is not just endless time. It is a relationship, knowing God through Christ. He says he has finished the work he was given, and asks to be restored to the glory he had with the Father before the world existed. The Son who is about to die speaks as if it is finished, because it is certain.

Then he prays for the eleven. They are the Father’s gift to him, and he has given them the Father’s word. He prays, “I am not praying for the world but for those whom you have given me.” He asks that the Father keep them in his name, that they may be one. He does not ask that they be taken out of the world, but kept from the evil one. They are in the world but not of the world. And he asks, “Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth.” To be sanctified is to be set apart and made holy, and it happens through the Word. Then, “As you sent me into the world, so I have sent them into the world.” The disciples are sent as he was sent.

The third part is for you, if you believe. “I do not ask for these only, but also for those who will believe in me through their word.” Jesus prayed for every future believer. He asks that they all may be one, “just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you.” The unity of believers reflects the unity of the Father and Son, and its purpose is mission: “so that the world may believe that you have sent me.” A divided church makes the gospel harder to believe. A united church is a witness.

He ends with the destination: “Father, I desire that they also, whom you have given me, may be with me where I am, to see my glory.” The goal of salvation is to be with Christ and to see him. And he says that the love of the Father for the Son will be in them. We are loved with the same love.

Notice how the prayer shows the security of the believer. The Son is praying for us, and the Father always hears him. As Romans 8:34 says, he is at the right hand of God, interceding for us.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 28 and Leviticus 16 describe the high priest's work. Hebrews 4:14-16 and 7:23-25 say Jesus is our great high priest who always lives to make intercession. Romans 8:34 says Christ intercedes for us. Isaiah 53:12 says he makes intercession for the transgressors. Ephesians 4:1-6 calls for the unity of the Spirit. Luke 22:32 records his prayer for Peter. 1 John 5:20 says to know the true God is eternal life. Revelation 21:3 promises that God will dwell with his people.

STEP 6

Application

Remember that Jesus has prayed for you by name. Write one sentence about what that means.

Pray this prayer back: for your own sanctification by the word, for your church's unity, and for the world to believe.

Reach out to a Christian from another tradition or community this week, as a sign of unity.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for praying for you before you were born.

Thank God that eternal life is knowing him.

Ask him to make you one with his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 661 · WEEK 95

John 18:1-19:16

Arrest; trials; Pilate

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 18:1-19:16. Jesus is arrested in a garden, questioned, denied by Peter, tried before Pilate, and sentenced to be crucified. Notice who is really in control, and the conversation about kingship and truth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the prayer, Jesus crosses the Kidron valley to a garden, where Judas arrives with soldiers and officials. John tells the story of the trial from a different angle than the other Gospels. He leaves out Gethsemane's agony and the Jewish council's formal verdict, and emphasizes Jesus' sovereignty. The key scenes are the confrontation in the garden, the interview with Pilate, and the cry of the crowd.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Put your sword into its sheath; shall I not drink the cup that the Father has given me?" (18:11).
2. "Peter again denied it, and at once a rooster crowed" (18:27).
3. "My kingdom is not of this world" (18:36).
4. "Everyone who is of the truth listens to my voice" (18:37).
5. "What is truth?" (18:38).
6. "Behold the man!" (19:5).
7. "You would have no authority over me at all unless it had been given you from above" (19:11).
8. "We have no king but Caesar" (19:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

When the soldiers come, Jesus steps forward: “Whom do you seek?” “Jesus of Nazareth.” “I am he.” And they draw back and fall to the ground. Even in his arrest, his majesty shows. He asks them to let his disciples go, and they do. Peter strikes with a sword, and Jesus says, “Shall I not drink the cup that the Father has given me?” He is not a victim of events. He is going to the cross willingly.

Peter follows at a distance. In the courtyard, he is asked whether he is a disciple, and he denies it. Three times. Then a rooster crows. Meanwhile, inside, Jesus is questioned by Annas and then Caiaphas, and struck by an officer.

Before Pilate, the leaders do not enter the Gentile governor’s headquarters so they will not be defiled before Passover, a terrible irony as they seek the death of the innocent. Pilate asks, “Are you the King of the Jews?” Jesus answers, “My kingdom is not of this world.” It is a real kingdom, but it does not rely on swords. “For this purpose I was born… to bear witness to the truth. Everyone who is of the truth listens to my voice.” Pilate’s famous answer is a question, “What is truth?” He is standing in front of the Truth and does not know it. He tells the crowd three times that he finds no guilt in Jesus.

Pilate has Jesus flogged, and the soldiers put a crown of thorns on his head and a purple robe on him. Pilate brings him out: “Behold the man!” The King wears a crown of thorns, and he is exactly the man we need. When the leaders cry “Crucify him!”, Pilate says, “You take him and crucify him.” They say he has made himself the Son of God. Pilate becomes more afraid. “Do you not know that I have authority to release you and authority to crucify you?” Jesus answers, “You would have no authority over me at all unless it had been given you from above.” God is in control, and yet Pilate and the leaders are guilty.

Finally the chief priests say, “We have no king but Caesar.” The people who had longed for centuries for God to be their King now renounce him. Pilate hands Jesus over to be crucified. The innocent Lamb is handed over on the day of preparation for the Passover, at the very hour the Passover lambs were being slaughtered.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 3:14 is the “I am he” that made the soldiers fall back. Isaiah 53:7-8 describes the silent servant. Psalm 2:1-6 describes the nations raging against the LORD’s anointed. Daniel 7:14 gives the Son of Man a kingdom. Exodus 12 is the Passover lamb. 1 Timothy 6:13 says Christ Jesus made the good confession before Pilate. Romans 5:8 says Christ died for us while we were sinners. Acts 2:23 says he was delivered up according to the definite plan of God.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on Peter's denial and Jesus' willingness to restore him. Bring any denial of your own to Jesus.

Ask what it would mean to let Christ be your King in an area you've kept for yourself.

Meditate on "Behold the man!" for a few minutes in silence.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for going willingly to the cross.

Confess where you have not listened to his kingdom's call.

Ask him to teach you to belong to his kingdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 662 · WEEK 95

John 19:17-42

The crucifixion, "It is finished"; the burial

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 19:17-42. Jesus is crucified, speaks his last words in John's Gospel, dies, and is buried. Read slowly. Notice how many Scriptures John says are fulfilled, and the cry "It is finished."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus carries his cross to Golgotha, the place of a skull. John, who was there, tells the story with simplicity and attention to detail. He alone records the conversation with his mother, the cry "I thirst," the word "It is finished," and the water and blood from his side. John presents the crucifixion not as defeat but as the hour of glory, the completion of the work the Father gave him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews" (19:19).
2. "They divided my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots" (19:24).
3. "Woman, behold, your son!" (19:26).
4. "I thirst" (19:28).
5. "It is finished" (19:30).
6. "And he bowed his head and gave up his spirit" (19:30).
7. "But one of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and at once there came out blood and water" (19:34).
8. "Nicodemus, who earlier had come to Jesus by night, also came, bringing a mixture of myrrh and aloes, about seventy-five pounds in weight" (19:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pilate writes a sign for the cross: “Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews,” in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek. The chief priests object, but Pilate says, “What I have written I have written.” Without knowing it, Pilate proclaims the truth to the world in three languages.

The soldiers divide his clothes into four parts and cast lots for the seamless tunic, fulfilling Psalm 22:18. John notes that nothing happens by accident. Near the cross stand his mother, her sister, Mary the wife of Clopas, and Mary Magdalene. Jesus sees his mother and the disciple whom he loved, and says, “Woman, behold, your son!” and “Behold, your mother!” Even in agony, he provides for his mother.

Then, “knowing that all was now finished,” he says, “I thirst.” Psalm 69:21 is fulfilled. They put a sponge of sour wine on a hyssop branch. Hyssop was used at the Passover to put the blood on the doorposts. Then he says, “It is finished,” and bows his head and gives up his spirit. The word is tetelestai, a word used for a paid debt. Jesus did not die as a helpless victim but as someone who completed the work of redemption: the debt paid, the sacrifice offered, the law fulfilled, the Father’s will done. He gave up his spirit; it was not taken from him.

To make sure the bodies do not remain on the crosses on the Sabbath, the soldiers break the legs of the other two men. But when they come to Jesus, they find that he is already dead, and instead a soldier pierces his side with a spear. Blood and water flow out. John emphasizes that he saw it and testifies to it. Not a bone is broken, fulfilling the Passover regulations about the lamb, and they will look on the one they have pierced (Zechariah 12:10). Jesus is the Passover Lamb.

Joseph of Arimathea, a secret disciple, and Nicodemus, who first came by night, step forward in the open. Nicodemus brings a hundred pounds of spices, a royal burial. They wrap the body and lay it in a new tomb in a garden, where no one had yet been laid. Two men who had been afraid now publicly honor Jesus. Death has done its worst. The scene is set for Sunday.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 describes the crucifixion with striking accuracy, and verses 16 to 18 are quoted here. Psalm 69:21 is the vinegar. Exodus 12:22 and 12:46 relate to hyssop and the unbroken bones. Zechariah 12:10 is the pierced one. Isaiah 53:9 says he was with a rich man in his death. Leviticus 16 and Hebrews 9:11-14 explain the sacrifice of atonement. Romans 3:23-26 and Colossians 2:13-14 say the debt of our sin was nailed to the cross. 1 John 5:6-8 speaks of water and blood.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time in silence with “It is finished.” What debt do you still try to pay on your own?

Look at Joseph and Nicodemus: are you hiding your faith? Ask for courage to be open.

Thank Jesus for caring for his mother even in agony. Whom can you care for today?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for saying, “It is finished,” and paying your debt in full.

Tell him what it means to rest in that.

Thank him for his care even in his dying.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

“But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name.”

JOHN 20:31

DAY 663 · WEEK 95

John 20:1-21:25

The resurrection; Thomas; the reinstatement of Peter

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 20:1-21:25. The empty tomb, the appearance to Mary Magdalene, to the disciples, and to Thomas, the purpose statement of the Gospel, and a breakfast on the beach where Jesus restores Peter. Read 20:30-31 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is early on the first day of the week, while it is still dark. Mary Magdalene comes to the tomb and finds the stone taken away. John's account is intimate and personal. He tells of his own race with Peter to the tomb, of Mary's tears, of Thomas's doubt, and of a morning by the Sea of Tiberias. The Gospel was originally written to end at chapter 20; chapter 21 is an epilogue that answers Peter's denial.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Jesus said to her, Mary. She turned and said to him in Aramaic, Rabboni!" (20:16).
2. "As the Father has sent me, even so I am sending you" (20:21).
3. "My Lord and my God!" (20:28).
4. "Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed" (20:29).
5. "But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name" (20:31).
6. "Simon, son of John, do you love me more than these?" (21:15).
7. "Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you" (21:17).
8. "Follow me" (21:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mary finds the tomb empty and runs to tell Peter and John. They run to the tomb. John arrives first but Peter goes in first, and they see the linen cloths lying there. John "saw and believed." Mary stays outside, weeping. Two angels ask why she is weeping, and then she turns and sees Jesus, but does not recognize him, thinking he is the gardener. He says one word: "Mary." She knows his voice. "Rabboni!" The good shepherd calls his sheep by name. He sends her to the disciples: "I am ascending to my Father and your Father, to my God and your God."

That evening, the disciples are behind locked doors. Jesus stands among them: "Peace be with you." He shows them his hands and side. "As the Father has sent me, even so I am sending you." He breathes on them and says, "Receive the Holy Spirit." He gives them authority to proclaim the forgiveness of sins.

Thomas was not there. He says he will not believe unless he sees the nail marks and puts his hand in his side. A week later, Jesus appears again. "Put your finger here, and see my hands." Thomas does not need to touch. He says the greatest confession in the Gospel: "My Lord and my God!" Jesus says, "Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed." That includes every Christian since.

Then John states his purpose. Jesus did many other signs, but these are written "so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name." John selected his signs to produce faith. Everything in this Gospel is to bring us to belief, and life.

Chapter 21 shows Peter, who denied Jesus three times by a charcoal fire, restored by another charcoal fire. Seven disciples have gone fishing and caught nothing. A man on the shore tells them to cast on the right side, and the net is full. "It is the Lord!" Peter jumps in. On the beach Jesus has breakfast ready. Then he asks Peter three times, "Do you love me?" Peter is grieved, and says, "Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you." Each time Jesus gives him a charge: "Feed my lambs... Tend my sheep... Feed my sheep." The one who denied him is made a shepherd. Jesus also tells him how he will die and ends with "Follow me." The Gospel ends with John's note that the world could not contain the books if everything Jesus did were written.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2 and 3 take place in a garden, as does the resurrection in John. Psalm 16:10 and Isaiah 53:10-12 speak of the Messiah's rising. Genesis 2:7 describes the breath of life, echoed in 20:22. Ezekiel 37:9-14 speaks of breath and the Spirit giving life. Luke 24:36-49 gives the

parallel appearance. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the witnesses to the resurrection. 1 Peter 1:8 says that though you have not seen him, you love him. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is Peter's later call to shepherd the flock.

STEP 6

Application

Hear Jesus call your name as he called Mary's. Respond with "Rabboni."

Confess with Thomas, "My Lord and my God," and mean it.

If you have failed Jesus, hear him ask, "Do you love me?" and answer honestly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say to Jesus, "My Lord and my God," and mean it.
- Thank him for calling you by name.
- Hear him ask, "Do you love me?" and answer him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 664 · WEEK 95

Review and Reflection

Unit 17 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, John

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life."
>
> JOHN 3:16

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to Nicodemus in the night, and it has become the best known verse in the Bible. Every word carries weight.

"For God." The subject of the sentence is God. Salvation begins with him, not us.

"So loved." The word "so" means "in this way." This is how God loved: by giving. His love is not a feeling alone. It acts, at great cost.

"The world." Not just Israel, not just the good. The whole sinful, rebellious world. If God loved the world, he loves you.

"That he gave his only Son." The Father gave the Son he loved from all eternity. This is the gift of the cross, the greatest gift in history.

"That whoever believes in him." The way to receive the gift is belief, trust in Jesus. "Whoever" means anyone, with no exceptions.

"Should not perish but have eternal life." Two destinies: perishing or life. Eternal life begins now, in knowing God, and lasts forever.

When you doubt whether God cares about you, say this verse. It is the gospel in a sentence.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the whole Gospel of John, which was written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and by believing have life in his name. It began in eternity with the Word, who was with God and was God, and who became flesh and dwelt among us, full of grace and truth. Through seven signs and seven "I AM" statements, John showed who Jesus is: the bread of life, the light of the world, the door, the good shepherd, the resurrection and the life, the way, the truth, and the life, and the true vine. Jesus told Nicodemus that he must be born again, offered living water to a Samaritan woman, healed a blind man, and raised Lazarus. He said "Before Abraham was, I am," and "I and the Father are one." In the Upper Room he washed his disciples' feet, gave a new commandment, and promised the Holy Spirit, the Helper who would be with them forever. He taught them to abide in the vine and prayed for all who would believe through their word. He was arrested, tried, and crucified, saying "It is finished," and was raised on the third day. He called Mary by name, drew Thomas from doubt to worship, and restored Peter. Along the way you doctrinally paused on the incarnation, regeneration, and worship, and prayed through Psalms 36, 139, 119, 43, 23, 100, and 103, which gave voice to the light, the shepherd, and the steadfast love at the heart of this Gospel.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the Prologue teach about the identity of Jesus?

Reread John 1:1-18. Notice what it says about the Word's relationship to God, to creation, and to us. Write a few sentences about why it matters that Jesus is both fully God and fully human.

What do the seven "I AM" statements reveal about who Jesus is?

List them: the bread of life (6:35), the light of the world (8:12), the door (10:9), the good shepherd (10:11), the resurrection and the life (11:25), the way, the truth, and the life (14:6), and the true vine (15:1). Choose the one that speaks most to your need right now and say why.

What does the Upper Room Discourse teach about the Holy Spirit?

Look at John 14:16-26, 15:26-27, and 16:7-15. What does the Spirit do for believers and for the world? Why did Jesus say it was to their advantage that he go away?

What does "abiding in the vine" look like in everyday Christian life?

Reread John 15:1-17. Think about concrete practices of abiding, such as prayer, Scripture, obedience, and fellowship. Describe one change you could make this week to stay more connected to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for loving the world so much that he gave his Son.
- Thank him for what John has shown you of Jesus.
- Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 665 · WEEK 95

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 20:31 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

REST

Meditation

John writes these words at the end of his Gospel, and they tell us why he wrote it. It is the key to reading everything else in the book.

"These are written." The Gospel is a written testimony, chosen from many things Jesus did. John, who saw and heard, put down what we need to know.

"So that you may believe." The purpose is faith. John does not write only to inform us. He writes to bring us to trust in Jesus.

"That Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God." Two titles sum up the content of faith: Christ, the promised king and Savior of Israel, and Son of God, the one who shares the nature of the Father. To believe both is to believe the gospel.

"And that by believing." Faith is the means, not the cause. We are not saved by our faith as a work, but through faith in a person.

“You may have life in his name.” The result is life: forgiveness, new birth, the Spirit, and eternal life, all in the name of Jesus. “In his name” means in the authority and character of his person.

When you wonder what the point of all this reading is, say this verse. It is for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week Jesus taught you to abide in the true vine, because apart from him you can do nothing, and promised the Helper, the Spirit of truth. In the High Priestly Prayer you overheard the Son pray for you, that you would know the only true God, be kept from the evil one, be sanctified by the truth, and be one with his people. You followed Jesus through the garden, the trials before Annas, Caiaphas, and Pilate, and to the cross, where he said “It is finished.” You saw the burial by Joseph and Nicodemus, and the empty tomb. You heard him call Mary by name, watched Thomas confess “My Lord and my God,” and listened as Jesus restored Peter with three questions about love. You finished the Gospel of John and stated its purpose: that you may believe and have life in his name.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said, “Apart from me you can do nothing.” Where have you been trying to bear fruit on your own, and what would it look like to abide instead?

On the cross, Jesus said, “It is finished.” How does knowing that the work of salvation is complete change the way you live with your guilt and your efforts?

Jesus restored Peter after his denial and gave him a calling. What failure do you need to bring to Jesus, and what would it look like to hear him say “Follow me”?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the vine, the prayer, the cross, and the empty tomb.

Thank him for writing these things so that you may believe.

Rest in him.